



IELTS family

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BOOST YOUR VOCABULARY

• Second Edition •

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academic words from

CAMBRIDGE IELTS 15

TEST 1

READING PASSAGE 1



Nutmeg

a valuable spice

The nutmeg tree, *Myristica fragrans*, is a large **evergreen** tree **native to** Southeast Asia. Until the late 18th century, it only grew in one place in the world: a small group of islands in the Banda Sea, part of the Moluccas — or Spice Islands — in northeastern Indonesia. The tree is thickly **branched** with **dense** **foliage** of **tough**, dark green **oval** leaves, and produces small, yellow, **bell-shaped** flowers and **pale** yellow **pear-shaped** fruits. The fruit is **encased in a fleshy husk**. When the fruit is **ripe**, this **husk splits into** two halves along a **ridge** running the length of the fruit, inside is a

nutmeg= a brown powder made from the seed of a tropical tree, which is used as a spice
valuable= important, beneficial, worthy #worthless
spice= a type of powder or seed, taken from plants, that you put into food you are cooking to give it a special taste
myristica fragrans= east indian tree widely cultivated in the tropics for its aromatic seed
evergreen= an evergreen tree or bush does not lose its leaves in winter
native to= indigenous, local, aboriginal, resident #foreign
branch= split, fork, divide
dense= thick, close together #transparent
foliage= leaves
tough= not easily broken or made weaker
oval= ovate, egg-shaped
bell-shaped= shaped like a bell
pale= pallid, faint, weak #strong
pear-shaped= shaped like a pear
encase sth in sth= cover, enclose, wrap #uncover
fleshy= having a soft thick inner part
husk= shell, pod, covering #kernel
ripe= fully grown, mature
split into= divide, separate, break up, #united
ridge= edge, point

purple-brown **shiny seed**, 2-3 cm long by about 2 cm across, **surrounded** by a **lacy** red or **crimson** covering called an ‘**aril**’. These are the **sources** of the two **spices** **nutmeg** and **mace**, the **former** being produced from the dried **seed** and the **latter** from the **aril**.

Nutmeg was a highly **prized** and **costly** **ingredient** in European **cuisine** in the **Middle Ages**, and was used as a **flavouring**, **medicinal**, and **preservative agent**.

Throughout this **period**, the Arabs were the **exclusive** **importers** of the **spice** to Europe. They sold **nutmeg** for high prices to **merchants based in Venice**, but they never **revealed** the exact location of the **source** of this extremely **valuable commodity**. The Arab-Venetian **dominance** of the trade finally ended in 1512, when the Portuguese **reached** the Banda Islands and began **exploiting** its **precious** **resources**.

Always in **danger of** **competition** from neighbouring Spain, the Portuguese began **subcontracting** their **spice distribution** to Dutch **traders**. Profits began to **flow into** the Netherlands, and the Dutch **commercial fleet** **swiftly** grew into one of the largest in the world. The Dutch quietly gained control of most of the shipping and trading of **spices** in Northern Europe. Then, in 1580, Portugal **fell under** Spanish **rule**, and by the end of the 16th century the Dutch **found** themselves **locked out of** the market. As prices for pepper, nutmeg, and other spices **soared**

shiny= glossy, gleaming, sparkly
seed= one of the small hard objects in a fruit such as an apple or orange, from which new fruit trees grow
surround= enclose, encircle, envelop
lacy= made of lace
crimson= deep red in colour
aril= an extra seed covering, typically coloured and hairy or fleshy
mace= a spice made from the dried shell of a nutmeg
former= previous, past, earlier, prior
latter= last, later, final #former, previous

prized= extremely important or valuable to someone
costly= expensive, high, exorbitant
ingredient= element, component, part, item, thing
cuisine= food, cooking
middle ages= the period in European history between about 1100 and 1500 ad
flavouring= a substance used to give something a particular flavour or increase its flavour
medicinal= used for treating medical problems
preservative= conserving, preserving, protective
#destructive
agent= a chemical or substance that is used for a particular purpose or that has a particular effect
exclusive= sole, limited #partial
importer= a person, company, or country that buys goods from other countries so they can be sold in their own country
merchant= wholesaler, trader, dealer
be based in sth= to have your main place of work, business etc in a particular place
reveal= tell, expose, disclose #conceal
commodity= product, goods
dominance of= supremacy, domination, control, power, ascendancy #weakness
reach= arrive, go, move
exploit= use, utilize, make use of, take advantage of
precious= valuable, treasurable, priceless #worthless
resource= source, reserve, supply

be in danger of (doing) sth= risk, threat, hazard, endangerment #safety
subcontract sth to sb= if a company subcontracts work, they pay other people to do part of their work for them
distribution= supply, spreading, delivery
trader= dealer, merchant, seller
flow into sth= run, pour, flood
commercial= business-related, for-profit #charitable
fleet= a group of ships, or all the ships in a navy
swiftly= quickly, speedily, rapidly #slowly
fall under= to be influenced or affected by (something)
lock sb out of sth= to prevent a person or organization from having or being able to take part in something
soar= climb, rocket, rise, increase, #decrease, drop, plummet

across Europe, they decided to **fight back**.

In 1602, Dutch **merchants** **founded** the VOC, a trading **corporation** better known as the Dutch East India Company. By 1617, the VOC was the richest **commercial** operation in the world. The company had 50,000 employees **worldwide**, with a private **army** of 30,000 men and a **fleet** of 200 ships. At the same time, thousands of people across Europe were dying of the **plague**, a highly **contagious** and deadly disease. Doctors were **desperate** for a way to stop the **spread** of this disease, and they decided **nutmeg** held the **cure**. Everybody wanted **nutmeg**, and many were willing to **spare no expense** to have it. **Nutmeg** bought for a few **pennies** in Indonesia could be sold for 68,000 times its original cost on the sweets of London. The only problem was the short supply. And that's where the Dutch **found** their opportunity.

The Banda Islands were **ruled** by local **sultans** who **insisted on** maintaining a **neutral** trading **policy** towards foreign **powers**. This allowed them to avoid the presence of Portuguese or Spanish **troops** on their soil, but it also left them **unprotected** from other **invaders**. In 1621, the Dutch arrived and **took over**. Once securely in control of the Bandas, the Dutch went to work protecting their new investment. They **concentrated** all **nutmeg** production into a few easily **guarded** areas, **uprooting** and destroying any trees outside the **plantation zones**. Anyone **caught** growing a **nutmeg seedling** or carrying seeds without the **proper** authority was severely punished. In addition, all exported **nutmeg** was covered with **lime** to make sure there was no chance a **fertile** seed which could be grown elsewhere would leave the islands. There was only one **obstacle** to Dutch **domination**. One of the Banda Islands, a **sliver** of land

fight back= to work hard to achieve or oppose something, especially in a situation where you are losing

merchant= wholesaler, trader, dealer

found= start, create, establish, set up #close

corporation= company, business, firm, organization

army= large organized group of people trained to fight on land in a war

plague= disease, epidemic, pandemic, illness

contagious= transmissible, transmittable, infectious

desperate= anxious, worried, frantic, hopeless #calm

spread= if something spreads or is spread, it becomes larger or moves so that it affects more people or a larger area

cure= treatment, therapy, medication

spare no expense to do sth= to spend as much money or do everything necessary to make something really good or successful

penny - pennies (plural) = a small unit of money in Britain. there are 100 pence in one pound

rule= govern, reign, lead, control

sultan= a ruler in some muslim countries

insist on= require, enforce, oblige

neutral= unbiased, impartial #biased

power= authority, control, supremacy

troop= crowd, flock, group

unprotected= defenseless, insecure, vulnerable

invader= attacker, assailant, intruder

take over= take control, take charge, come to power

concentrate= collect, mass, assemble #disperse

guarded= secured, protected, watched

uproot= deracinate, pull up, dig up #plant

plantation= farm, agricultural estate, cultivated area

zone= area, region, sector

catch sb doing sth= to see someone doing something that they did not want you to know they were doing

seedling= sprout, sapling, plantlet

proper= appropriate, suitable, apt.

authority= permission, license, mandate

lime= a white substance obtained by burning limestone, used for making cement, marking sports fields etc

fertile= able to produce babies, young animals, or new plants #infertile

obstacle= problem, difficulty, hindrance

domination= power, control, authority, supremacy, government

sliver= a small pointed or thin piece that has been cut or broken off something

called Run, only 31cm long by less than 1 km wide, was **under the control of** the British. After decades of fighting for control of this tiny island, the Dutch and British **arrived at a compromise settlement**, the **Treaty** of Breda, in 1667.

Intent on securing their **hold** over every **nutmeg**-producing island, the Dutch offered a **trade**: if the British would give them the island of Run, they would **in turn** give Britain a **distant** and much less **valuable** island in North America. The British agreed. That other island was Manhattan, which is how New Amsterdam became New York. The Dutch now had a **monopoly** over the nutmeg trade which would last for another century.

Then, in 1770, a Frenchman named Pierre Poivre successfully **smuggled nutmeg** plants to safety in Mauritius, an island **off the coast** of Africa. Some of these were later exported to the Caribbean where they **thrived**, especially on the island of Grenada. Next, in 1778, a **volcanic eruption** in the Banda region caused a **tsunami** that **wiped out** half the nutmeg **groves**. Finally, in 1809, the British returned to Indonesia and **seized** the Banda Islands **by force**. They returned the islands to the Dutch in 1817, but not before **transplanting** hundreds of nutmeg **seedlings to plantations** in several locations across southern Asia. The Dutch **nutmeg monopoly** was over.

Today, **nutmeg** is grown in Indonesia, the Caribbean, India, Malaysia, Papua New Guinea and Sri Lanka, and world **nutmeg** production is **estimated to average** between 10,000 and 12,000 tonnes per year.

under the control of sb= the power to make the decisions about how a country, place, company etc is organized or what it does
arrive at a decision/solution/compromise etc= to reach a decision, solution etc after a lot of effort
compromise= arrangement, agreement, deal
settlement= resolution, conclusion, decision, agreement
treaty= agreement, accord, pact, truce

intent on= to be determined to do something or achieve something
hold= control, power, influence
trade= when you exchange something you have for something that someone else has
in turn= as a result of something
distant= remote, far, isolated #near
monopoly= if a company or government has a monopoly of a business or political activity, it has complete control of it so that other organizations cannot compete with it

smuggle= to take something or someone illegally from one country to another
off the coast= the area where the land meets the sea
thrive= flourish, grow well #fail
volcanic= relating to or caused by a volcano
eruption= outbreak, explosion, emission
tsunami= tidal wave
wipe out= destroy, eradicate, devastate, remove
#protect
grove= plantation, copse, a piece of land with trees growing on it
seize= capture, conquer, take control of, take over
by force= violent physical action used to get what you want
transplant= relocate, resettle, uproot

estimate= guess, assess, appraise

READING PASSAGE 2



Driverless Cars

A

The **automotive sector** is well used to **adapting to automation** in **manufacturing**. The **implementation** of robotic car **manufacture** from the 1970s **onwards** led to **significant cost savings** and improvements in the **reliability** and **flexibility** of vehicle **mass production**. A new challenge to vehicle production is now **on the horizon** and, again, it comes from **automation**.

However, this time it is not to do with the **manufacturing** process, but with the vehicles themselves.

Research projects on vehicle **automation** are not new. Vehicles with limited **self-driving capabilities** have been around for more than 50 years, resulting in **significant contributions** towards driver **assistance** systems. But

driverless= a driverless vehicle is controlled by equipment in the vehicle, rather than by a human driver

automotive= motorized, locomotive, relating to cars

sector= area, part, division

adapt to= acclimatize, adjust, modify

implementation= application, operation, carrying out

automation= the use of computers and machines instead of people to do a job

manufacture= production, making, construction

implementation= application, execution, enactment

onwards= forwards, ahead, straight on #backwards

significant= considerable, large, major #paltry

cost saving= money that a company has saved by deliberately spending less

reliability= dependability, consistency

flexibility= suppleness, elasticity

mass production= when products are made in large numbers by machines so that they can be sold cheaply

on the horizon= to seem likely to happen in the future

self-driving = used to refer to a vehicle that drives itself

capability= ability, capacity #inability

contribution= influence, involvement, impact

assistance= help, support, aid #hindrance

since Google **announced** in 2010 that it had been **trialling self-driving** cars on the streets of California, **progress** in this field has quickly **gathered pace**.

B

There are many reasons why technology is **advancing** so fast. One frequently **cited motive** is safety; **Indeed**, research at the UK's Transport **Research** Laboratory has **demonstrated** that more than 90 percent of road **collisions involve human error** as a **contributory** factor, and it is the **primary** cause in the **vast majority**.

Automation may help to reduce the **incidence** of this.

Another **aim** is to **free** the time people spend driving for other purposes. If the vehicle can do some or all of the driving, it may be possible to be **productive**, to **socialise** or simply to relax while **automation** systems **have responsibility** for safe control of the vehicle. If the vehicle can do the driving, those who are challenged by **existing mobility models** — such as older or disabled travellers — may be able to enjoy significantly greater travel **autonomy**.

C

Beyond these direct benefits, we can consider the **wider implications** for transport and society, and how **manufacturing** processes might need to **respond** as a result. At present, the **average** car spends more than 90 percent of its life **parked**. **Automation** means that **initiatives** for **car-sharing** become much more **viable**, particularly in urban areas with **significant** travel demand. If a **significant proportion** of the population choose to use shared **automated** vehicles, **mobility** demand can be met **by far** fewer vehicles.

announce= publicize, declare, say
trial= to thoroughly test something to see if it works correctly or is effective
progress= development, growth, improvement
#regression
gather pace= happen more quickly

advance= improve, develop, enhance
cite= mention, refer to
motive= reason, cause, purpose, intention, aim
indeed= certainly, actually, in fact
demonstrate= show, reveal, display **#conceal**
collision= crash, accident
involve= include, comprise, encompass
human error= an error that is typical of humans rather than machines
contributory= related, causal, influential
primary= main, key, chief, crucial
great/vast/overwhelming majority of sth= almost all of a group
incidence of= occurrence, prevalence, frequency, rate, numbers
aim= goal, purpose, objective, target, intention
free= release, set free, liberate
productive= producing or achieving a lot
socialize= to spend time with other people in a friendly way
have responsibility for (doing) sth= accountability, duty, charge
existing= current, present, prevailing
mobility= movement, motion **#immobility**
model= type, sort, kind, brand, version
autonomy= independence, self-sufficiency
#dependence

beyond= further than, away from
wider= broader, varied, wide-ranging **#narrower**
implication= effect, consequence, repercussion
respond= react, act in, response **#ignore**
average= normal, regular, typical, standard
park= to put a car or other vehicle in a particular place for a period of time
initiative= plan, idea, project, program
car-sharing= an arrangement in which a group of people travel together in one car to work or school
viable= feasible, practical, practicable **#impossible**
automated= automatic, robotic, computerized, programmed **#manual**
by far= used to say that something is much better, worse etc than anything else

D

The Massachusetts Institute of Technology investigated **automated mobility** in Singapore, finding that fewer than 30 percent of the vehicles **currently** used would be required if fully **automated** car sharing could be **implemented**. If **this is the case**, it might mean that we need to **manufacture** far fewer vehicles to meet demand. However, the number of trips being taken would probably increase, partly because **empty** vehicles would have to be moved from one customer to the next.

Modelling work by the University of Michigan Transportation Research Institute suggests automated vehicles might reduce vehicle **ownership** by 43 percent, but that vehicles' **average** annual **mileage** would double as a result. As a consequence, each vehicle would be used more **intensively**, and might need replacing sooner. This faster rate of **turnover** may mean that vehicle production will not necessarily decrease.

E

Automation may **prompt** other changes in vehicle **manufacture**. If we move to a model where consumers are tending not to **own** a **single** vehicle but to **purchase** access to a **range** of vehicles through a mobility provider, drivers will have the **freedom** to **select** one that best **suits** their needs for a particular journey, rather than **making a compromise** across all their requirements. Since, for most of the time, most of the seats in most cars are **unoccupied**, this may **boost** production of a smaller, more **efficient range** of vehicles that suit the needs of **individuals**. **Specialised** vehicles may then be **available** for **exceptional** journeys, such as going on a family camping trip or helping a son or daughter move to university.

implement= carry out, put into operation, put into action, apply

this is the case= a situation that exists, especially as it affects a particular person or group

modelling= the process of making a scientific or computer model of something to show how it works or to understand it better

ownership= possession, tenure, proprietorship

mileage= the number of miles someone travels in a vehicle in a particular period of time

intensively= in a way that involves a lot of activity, effort, or careful attention in a short period of time

turnover= the rate at which a particular kind of goods is sold

prompt= stimulate, encourage, motivate #prevent
a range of= a variety of, a mixture of, diverse, various

freedom= liberty, self-determination, independence, choice #restriction

select= choose, pick, opt for, decide on

suit= fit match, go well with, be appropriate

make a compromise= settlement, agreement, deal, bargain

unoccupied= vacant, empty, unused, unfilled #occupied

boost= increase, improve, enhance #reduce

efficient= if someone or something is efficient, they work well without wasting time, money, or energy

individual= person, being

specialized= trained, designed, or developed for a particular purpose, type of work, place etc exceptional

available= existing, free, untaken

exceptional= unusual and likely not to happen often

F

There are a number of **hurdles** to **overcome** in delivering automated vehicles to our roads. These include the technical difficulties in **ensuring** that the vehicle works **reliably** in the **infinite range** of traffic, weather and road situations it might **encounter**; the **regulatory** challenges in understanding how **liability** and **enforcement** might change when drivers are no longer **essential** for vehicle operation; and the **societal** changes that may be required for communities to trust and accept automated vehicles as being a **valuable** part of the mobility **landscape**.

G

It's clear that there are many challenges that need to be **addressed** but, through **robust** and **targeted** research, these can most probably be **conquered** within the next 10 years. Mobility will change in such potentially significant ways and **in association with** so many other technological developments, such as **telepresence** and **virtual reality**, that it is hard to make **concrete predictions** about the future. However, one thing is certain: change is coming, and the need to be **flexible in response to** this will be **vital** for those **involved in** manufacturing the vehicles that will **deliver** future mobility.

hurdle= obstacle, difficulty, problem, barrier, block
overcome= defeat, beat, conquer
ensure= guarantee, confirm, make sure, make certain
reliably= in a way that can be trusted or believed
infinite= boundless, limitless, vast #limited
encounter= face, confront, meet #avoid
regulatory= controlling, supervisory, monitoring
liability= obligation, responsibility, accountability
enforcement= when people are made to obey a rule, law etc
essential= vital, important, crucial, critical, needed, necessary #unnecessary
societal= social, shared, public, community
valuable= valued, precious, important
landscape= situation, circumstances

address= tackle, adopt, deal with #ignore
robust= a robust system, organization etc is strong and not likely to have problems
targeted= aimed, pointed
conquer= dominate, seize, occupy
in association with sb/sth= made or done with another person, organization etc
telepresence= the use of virtual reality technology to operate machinery by remote control or to create the effect of being at a different or imaginary location
virtual reality= an environment produced by a computer that looks and seems real to the person experiencing it
concrete= real, tangible, actual
prediction= forecast, guess, calculation
flexible= adaptable, variable, open
in response to sth= something that is done as a reaction to something that has happened or been said
vital= critical, crucial, important #unimportant
involve in= engage, include
deliver= bring, send, transport

READING PASSAGE 3

What is exploration?

We are all **explorers**. Our **desire** to discover, and then share that **new-found** knowledge, is part of what makes us human — **indeed**, this has **played an important part** in our success as a **species**. Long before the first **caveman slumped down** beside the fire and **grunted** news that there were plenty of **wildebeest** over **yonder**, our **ancestors** had learnt the value of **sending out scouts** to investigate the **unknown**. This **questing nature** of ours **undoubtedly** helped our **species** spread around the **globe**, just as it nowadays no **doubt** helps the last **nomadic** Penan maintain their **existence** in the

exploration= discovery, search
explorer= traveler, voyager
desire= wish, craving, aspiration
new-found= recently obtained, found, or achieved
indeed= actually, in fact, in reality
play a part/role= to have an effect or influence on something
species= class, type, kind, sort, group
caveman= someone who lived in a cave many thousands of years ago
slump down= drop, fall, crash, collapse #rise
grunt= mumble, murmur, make a sound
wildebeest= a large southern african animal with a tail and curved horns
yonder= over there – used to show or explain where something or someone is
ancestor= forefather, antecedent #descendant
send out= to make a person or a group of people or things go from one place to various other places
scout= detective, spy
the unknown= things that you do not know or understand
quest= search, hunt, seek #find
nature= someone's character
undoubtedly= certainly, unquestionably, undeniably, without doubt #doubtfully
globe= world, earth
doubt= uncertainty, disbelief #certainty
nomadic= if someone leads a nomadic life, they travel from place to place and do not live in any one place for very long
existence= life, presence, survival

depleted forests of Borneo, and a visitor **negotiate** the **subways** of New York.

Over the years, we've **come to** think of **explorers** as a **peculiar breed** — different from **the rest of us**, different from those of us who are **merely** 'well travelled', even; and perhaps there is a type of person more **suited** to **seeking out** the new, a type of **caveman** more **inclined** to **risk venturing out**. That, however, doesn't **take away from** the fact that we all have this **enquiring instinct**, even today; and that in all sorts of **professions** — whether artist, **marine** biologist or **astronomer** — **borders of the unknown** are being **tested** each day.

Thomas Hardy set some of his novels in Egdon Heath, a **fictional** area of **uncultivated** land, and used the **landscape** to **suggest** the **desires** and fears of his **characters**. He is **delving into** matters we all recognise because they are common to **humanity**. This is surely an act of **exploration**, and into a world as **remote** as the author chooses. **Explorer** and travel writer Peter Fleming talks of the moment when the **explorer** returns to the **existence** he has left behind with his loved ones. The traveller 'who has for weeks or months seen himself only as a **puny** and **irrelevant alien** **crawling laboriously over** a country in which he has no **roots** and no **background**, suddenly **encounters** his other self, a **relatively solid** figure, with a place in the minds of certain people'.

depleted= reduced, drained, diminished
negotiate= pass, navigate, go around
subway= a path for people to walk under a road or railway

come to do sth= to begin to have a feeling or opinion
peculiar= strange, weird, unusual, abnormal #normal
breed= type, class, kind, sort
the rest of= what is left after everything or everyone else has gone, been used, dealt with, or mentioned
merely= just, only, simply, purely
suited= suitable, appropriate, fit
seek out= to try to find someone or something, especially when this is difficult
inclined= to be likely to do something or behave in a particular way
risk= hazard, venture, take the risk of, take a chance
venture out= to go somewhere that could be dangerous
take away from= to spoil the good effect or success that something has
enquiring= interested, curious, questioning
instinct= nature, character, predisposition
profession= job, career, vocation
marine= relating to the sea and the creatures that live there
astronomer= stargazer, starwatcher, astronomer,
border= edge, limit, boundary, margin
test= examine, check, assess

fictional= imaginary, imagined, fantastic #real
uncultivated= fallow, unplanted, unfarmed #cultivated
landscape= scenery, land, site, scene
suggest= propose, recommend, put forward
character= a person in a book, play, film etc
delve into= explore, research, examine, look into
humanity= humankind, people, human race
remote= far, distant, faraway
puny= a puny person is small, thin, and weak
irrelevant= immaterial #relevant
alien= extra-terrestrial, extraterrestrial, creature from outer space, space invader
crawl over= if an insect crawls, it moves using its legs
laboriously= arduously, strenuously, hard #easily
root= origin, derivation, foundation
background= someone's family, education, previous work etc
encounter= meet, come across, bump into
relatively= quite, rather, comparatively
solid= hard or firm, with a fixed shape, and not a liquid or gas

In this book about the **exploration** of the earth's **surface**, I have **confined** myself to those whose travels were real and who also aimed at more than personal discovery. But that still **left** me **with** another problem: the word '**explorer**' has become **associated** with a **past era**. We think back to a **golden age**, as if **exploration peaked somehow** in the 19th century — **as if** the process of discovery is now on the **decline**, though the truth is that we have named only one and a half million of this planet's **species**, and there may be more than 10 million — and that's not including **bacteria**. We have studied only 5 per cent of the **species** we know. We have **scarcely** mapped the **ocean floors**, and how even less about ourselves; we fully understand the **workings** of only 10 per cent of our brains.

Here is how some of today's '**explorers**' **define** the word. Ran Fienness, **dubbed** the 'greatest living **explorer**', said, 'An **explorer** is someone who has done something that no human has done before — and also done something **scientifically** useful.' Chris Bonington, a **leading mountaineer**, felt **exploration** was to be **found in the act** of physically touching the **unknown**: 'You have to have gone somewhere new.' Then Robin Hanbury-Tenison, a **campaigner on behalf of remote so-called 'tribal'** peoples, said, 'A traveller simply records information about some **far-off** world, and reports back; but an **explorer** changes the world.' Wilfred Thesiger, who **crossed** Arabia's Empty Quarter in 1946, and belongs to an **era** of **unmechanised** travel now lost to the **rest** of us, told me, 'If I'd gone across by **camel** when I could have gone by car, it would have been a **stunt**.' To him, **exploration** meant **bringing back** information from a **remote** place **regardless** of any great **self-discovery**.

surface= outside, facade, exterior
confine yourself to (doing) sth= restrict, restrain, limit, keep
leave sb with sth= if an event, accident, illness etc leaves you in a particular condition, you are in that condition because of it
associated= related, linked, connected
past= previous, earlier, preceding
era= age, period, time
golden age= period during which sth is very successful, especially in the past
as if= in a way that makes it seem that something is true or that something is happening
peak= top, climax #dip
somehow= in some way, or by some means, although you do not know how
bacteria= microorganisms, microbes, germs
scarcely= barely, hardly #fully
map= to discover or show information about something, especially about its shape or arrangement, or how it moves or works
ocean floor= the bottom of a sea or ocean
the workings of sth= the way that an organization, machine or organism operates

define= describe, state, explain
dub= call, name, label
scientifically= in a way that relates to science, or uses the methods of science
leading= famous, outstanding, well-known
mountaineer= hiker, climber, walker, rock climber
in the act of doing sth= at the moment that you are doing something
campaigner= activist, supporter, promoter
on behalf of= instead of someone, or as their representative
so-called= used to show that something or someone is usually called a particular name
tribal= ethnic, clannish
far-off= far, remote, distant
cross= traverse, go across, cross over
unmechanised= not performed with machines or involving machines
camel= a large desert animal with a long neck and either one or two humps (=large raised parts) on its back
stunt= something that is done to attract people's attention, especially in advertising or politics
bring back= to start to use something again that was used in the past
regardless of= irrespective of, despite, notwithstanding, no matter, in spite of, apart from
#considering
self-discovery= the process of learning about yourself and your beliefs

Each **definition** is slightly different — and tends to **reflect** the field of **endeavour** of each **pioneer**. It was the same whoever I asked: the **prominent** historian would say **exploration** was a thing of the past, the **cutting-edge** scientist would say it was of the present. **And so on**. They each set their **own** particular **criteria**; the common factor in their **approach** being that they all had, unlike many of us who simply enjoy travel or discovering new things, both a very **definite objective from the outset** and also a **desire** to record their **findings**.

I'd best **declare** my **own bias**. As a writer, I'm interested in the **exploration** of ideas. I've done a great many **expeditions** and each one was **unique**. I've lived for months alone with **isolated** groups of people all around the world, even two '**uncontacted tribes**'. But none of these things is of the slightest interest to anyone unless, through my books, I've **found** a new **slant**, **explored** a new idea. Why? Because the world has **moved on**. The time has long passed for the great **continental voyages** — another walk to the **poles**, another **crossing** of the Empty Quarter. We know how the land **surface** of our planet lies; **exploration** of it is now down to the details — the habits of **microbes**, say, or the **grazing** behaviour of buffalo. **Aside from** the deep sea and deep **underground**, it's the **era** of **specialists**. However, this is to **disregard** the role the human mind has in **conveying remote** places; and this is what interests me: how a **fresh interpretation**, even of a well-travelled **route**, can give its readers new **insights**.

definition= explanation, description, meaning
slightly= marginally, vaguely #considerably
reflect= reveal, indicate, signal
endeavor= attempt, effort, try
pioneer= innovator, inventor, developer, creator, discoverer
prominent= famous, well-known, important, outstanding, renowned #obscure
historian= someone who studies history, or the history of a particular thing
cutting-edge= leading-edge, front-line, pioneering, innovative, radical #old-fashioned
scientist= someone who works or is trained in science
and so on/forth=used at the end of a list to show that you could continue it in a similar way
criteria= standards, principles, measures, norms
approach= method, tactic, attitude
definite= sure, certain, fixed #uncertain, unsure
objective= object, purpose, aim, point, goal, intention
from the outset= from the beginning
finding= the information that someone has discovered as a result of their study, work etc

declare= state, announce, assert, say publicly
bias= prejudice, partiality, favoritism, predisposition, preference #impartiality
expedition= voyage, excursion, trip, journey
unique= sole, exclusive, exceptional, distinctive
#common
isolated= remote, lonely, cut off
uncontacted tribes= referred to lost tribes, are communities who live, or have lived without significant contact with global civilization
slant= viewpoint, attitude, perspective
move on= progress, move ahead, go on
continental= mainland, inland, interior, central, main land
voyage= relating to a large mass of land
pole= the most northern or most southern point on a planet, especially the earth
microbe= bug, germ, bacteria, microorganism
graze= if an animal grazes, or if you graze it, it eats grass that is growing
aside from= besides, apart from, except for
underground= under the earth's surface
specialist= expert, professional
disregard= ignore, discount, forget
convey= communicate, send, pass on, express
fresh= good or interesting because it has not been done, seen etc before
interpretation= clarification, understanding, explanation
route= way, road, path
insight= vision, perception, awareness